Making the Most of Multisite Evaluations

AEA/CDC Summer Institute
June 15, 2009





UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

Note

This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation under Grant No. REC 0438545. Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the authors and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation.

Today's Agenda

- Overview and introductions
- What? Our research grounding
- So what? Implications for practice
- Now what? Application discussion

Session Goals

- Review the basics of UFE and PE
- Distinguish between participation and involvement in multisite settings
- Discuss how to increase the impact of multisite evaluations
- Apply these ideas to evaluation examples
- Brainstorm solutions to multisite evaluation involvement and use challenges

Think about your own evaluation experiences. . .

THREE-STEP INTERVIEW

Question

Think of a time when people truly used an evaluation that you were part of.

- Describe that evaluation.
- What distinguished it from other evaluations in which you have participated?

Our NSF-funded research study

"BEYOND EVALUATION USE"

UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

What This Research Was NOT…

Our study did not focus on the traditional notion of utilization-focused evaluation–

"intended use by intended users"

UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

What Our Research Studied

- What happens to project staff who take part in a large-scale, multisite program evaluation
- Secondary potential users at multiple sites who participate throughout the evaluation process
  - How their involvement potentially leads to use
  - "[Un]intended use by [un]intended users"

UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

"Beyond Evaluation Use" NSF Programs

Name of Program	Years of Evaluations
Local Systemic Change through Teacher Enhancement (LSC)	1995 – present
Advanced Technological Education (ATE)	1998 - 2005
Collaboratives for Excellence in Teacher Preparation (CETP)	1999 - 2005
Building Evaluation Capacity of STEM Projects: Math Science Partnership Research Evaluation and Technical Assistance Project (MSP-RETA)	2002 – present

UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

Definitions

- Program
  - a major national funding initiative
- Project
  - one of many smaller efforts funded under a single program
- Multisite
  - multiple program sites that participate in the conduct of cross-site evaluation activity (Straw & Herrell, 2002)

UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

Methodology

- Archival Review
- Project Leader and Evaluator Survey
- Interviews
- NSF PI Survey
- Journal Editor Inquiry
- Citation Analysis

UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

Research Limitations

- Difficult to control for variety of definitions in the field
- Memory issues for participants
- Lack of distinction between *program* and *project* in survey responses
- Sampling challenges and program variation

Research Strengths

- Unusual to receive funding for evaluation research
- Real world program examples
- Different from traditional utilization-focused evaluation focus
- Studied influence on the field and on projects themselves
- Use of varied and innovative methods

What are the ideas this research studied? What?

CONCEPTUAL GROUNDING

Overarching Concepts

- Evaluation use/influence
- Involvement
  - –Utilization-focused evaluation (UFE)
  - –Participatory evaluation (PE)

Traditional Types of Evaluation Use

Type	*Use For*	*Definition: The Use of Knowledge. . .*
Instrumental	Action	. . . for making decisions
Conceptual or Enlightenment	Understanding	. . . to better understand a program or policy
Political, Persuasive, or Symbolic	Justification	. . . to support a decision someone has already made or to persuade others to hold a specific opinion

Definitions in "Beyond Evaluation Use"

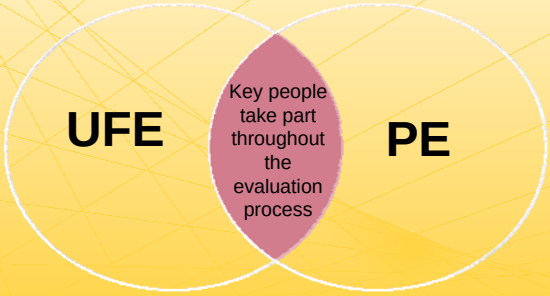
Term	Definition
Evaluation use	The purposeful application of evaluation processes, findings, or knowledge to produce an effect
Influence ***ON*** evaluation	The capacity of an individual to produce effects on an evaluation by direct or indirect means
Influence ***OF*** evaluation (from Kirkhart, 2000)	The capacity or power of evaluation to produce effects on others by intangible or indirect means

What Is Involvement?

- Not "participation"
- Not "engagement"
- Instead, think about how UFE and PE overlap

University of Minnesota

Overlap between UFE and PE



University of Minnesota

Utilization-focused Evaluation (UFE)

Evaluation done for and with **specific, *intended primary users*** for ***specific, intended uses***

-Patton (2008), *Utilization-Focused Evaluation, 4th Edition*

University of Minnesota

The **PERSONAL FACTOR** in Evaluation

"The presence of an identifiable individual or group of people who personally care about the evaluation and the findings it generates"



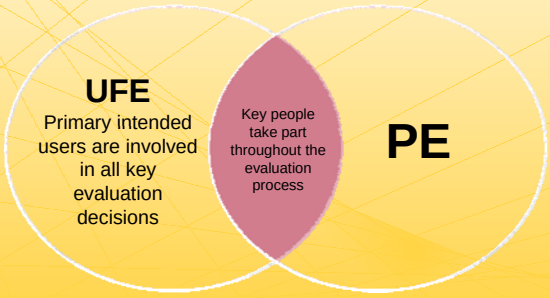
University of Minnesota

Key Collaboration Points in UFE

- Issues to examine (information primary intended users want/need)
- Methods to use (credibility in context)
- Analysis and interpretation of data
- Recommendations that will be useful

University of Minnesota

Overlap between UFE and PE



University of Minnesota

Participatory Evaluation (PE)

Range of definitions

- Active participation throughout all phases in the evaluation process by those with a stake in the program (King,1998)
- Broadening decision-making and problem-solving through systematic inquiry; reallocating power in the production of knowledge and promoting social changes (Cousins & Whitmore,1998)

UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

Principles of PE

- Participants OWN the evaluation
- The evaluator facilitates; participants plan and conduct the study
- People learn evaluation logic and skills as part of the process
- ALL aspects of the evaluation are understandable and meaningful
- Internal self-accountability is valued

(Adapted from Patton, 1997)

UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

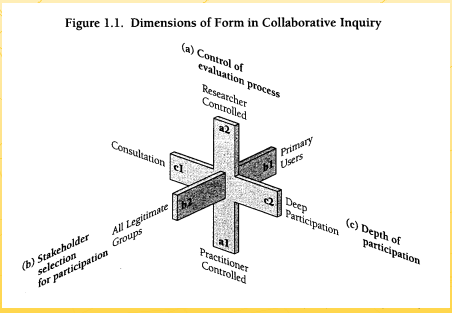
Characteristics of PE

1. **Control of the evaluation process** ranges from evaluator to practitioners
2. **Stakeholder selection for participation** ranges from primary users to "all legitimate groups"
3. **Depth of participation** ranges from consultation to deep participation

(From Cousins & Whitmore, 1998)

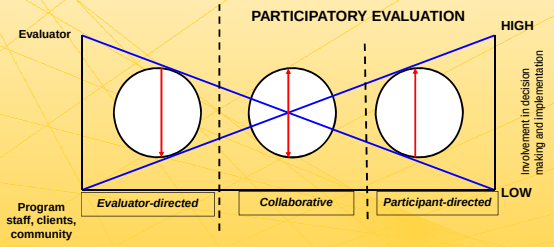
UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

Cousins & Whitmore Framework



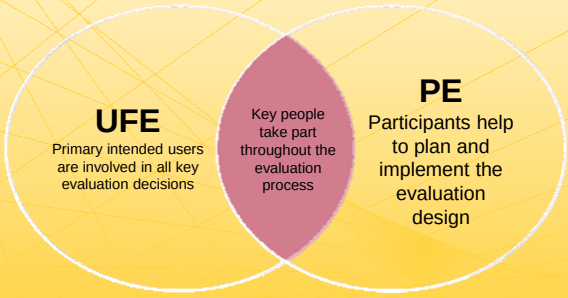
UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

Interactive Evaluation Quotient



UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

Overlap between UFE and PE



UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA



What happens when there are many sites involved in one study?

MULTI-SITE EVALUATIONS

University of Minnesota

Challenges of UFE/PE in Multisite Settings



- Projects vary
  - Activities – Goals –
  - Budgets -- Stakeholders
- Projects may be geographically diverse
  - Distance -- Cost
- Projects each have multiple stakeholders so the "project" becomes the key stakeholder (Lawrenz & Huffman, 2003)

University of Minnesota

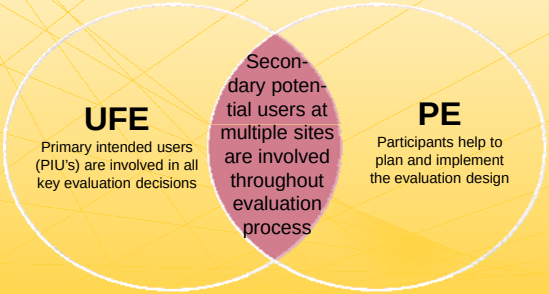


Prediction

How might UFE and PE play out in multisite evaluations (MSE's)?

University of Minnesota

The Focus of Our Research



University of Minnesota

After five years. . . so what?

WHAT DID WE FIND OUT?

University of Minnesota

What Our Research Found

- Secondary potential users **did** sometimes feel involved in the program evaluation and **did** sometimes use results
- What fostered feelings of involvement:
  - Meetings of all types; face-to-face best
  - Planning for use
  - The mere act of providing or collecting data

University of Minnesota

What Fostered Use

- Perception of a high quality evaluation
- Convenience, practicality, and alignment of evaluation materials (e.g., instruments)
- Feeling membership in a community

Remember the three-step interview results?



Implications for Practice

1. Don't expect too much of project staff
   - Consider different levels of involvement (depth OR breadth, not both necessarily)
   - Have projects serve as advisors or consultants
   - Have detail work completed by others/ outsiders
2. Address evaluation data concerns
   - Verify understanding of data definitions
   - Check accuracy (Does it make sense?)
   - Consider multiple analyses and interpretations

Implications for Practice (cont.)

3. Communicate, communicate, communicate
   -- Personal contact matters
4. Interface regularly with the funder
   - Understand the various contexts
   - Garner support for the program evaluation
   - Obtain help to promote involvement and use
   - Represent the projects back to the funder

Implications for Practice (cont.)

5. Recognize life cycles of people, projects, and the program
   - Involve more than one person per project
   - Understand the politics of projects
6. Expect tensions and conflict
   - Between project and program evaluation
   - Among projects (competition)
   - About how best to use resources

Implications for Practice (cont.)

7. Work to build community among projects and between projects/funder
   - Face-to-face interactions
   - Continuous communication
   - Asynchronous electronic communication
   - Be credible to project staff
     - Recognized expertise
     - "Guide on the side" not "sage on the stage"

Now what?

APPLICATION PRACTICE

Application Activity

Work in teams
to discuss
the assigned vignette.
[Try the checklist.]



Vignette Summaries

- Vignette #1 – HTTP
  - Training to increase healthcare technicians
  - Issue: Program-level evaluation not relevant to project-level evaluation
- Vignette #2 – MCC
  - Development of communications curricula for medical professional students
  - Issue: Projects do not use program-created evaluation tools and analysis

As you think about these ideas. . .



Questions?

Summary

- Involvement in MSEs is different from participation in single site evaluations
- Involvement does promote use
- There are several ways to foster participants' feelings of involvement
- Communication with participants and funders is critical

For Further Information

Online -
http://cehd.umn.edu/projects/beu/default.html

E-mail – Lawrenz@umn.edu

Presenters:

- Dr. Jean A. King
- Dr. Frances Lawrenz
- Dr. Stacie Toal
- Kelli Johnson
- Denise Roseland
- Gina Johnson